



ALLEN J. SCHABEN Los Angeles Times

VAST, a startup in Long Beach, plans to build a replacement for the \$150-billion International Space Station.

Rebound in aerospace sector propels the region’s economy

Startups seek out talent in the Southland, following Musk’s trajectory

By LAURENCE DARMIENTO

In a giant Long Beach warehouse near where Boeing used to build the C-17 cargo jet, Vast is fabricating what could be the first commercial space station to circle Earth.

Just up the road in El Se-

gundo, Varda Space Industries has grown molecular crystals in microgravity with few impurities for pharmaceuticals that one day could be injected in cancer patients.

And a little south in Seal Beach, a scrappy company called AstroForge aims to land a satellite on an asteroid just a football field wide

and mine possibly billions in platinum riches.

The companies aren’t anomalies but rather three examples of Southern California’s growing space economy, which shrank after the Cold War but is being revitalized with a new wave of startups pushing technological boundaries.

Southern California has

an illustrious aerospace heritage, starting with some of the first rocket experiments at what was to become the Jet Propulsion Laboratory — with the region later producing the X-15 rocket plane, the Apollo capsule and the space shuttles.

Today’s innovators are following in the flight path of [See **Aerospace**, A12]

COVID keeps roaring back in the summer

By many measures, the coronavirus is a thing of the past.

Masks have been stored away. Social distancing is just a vague memory. Interest in vaccines is waning. COVID, for many, feels like an inevitable annoyance, like the flu.

Then, each summer, we get a rude reminder.

The season of travel and fun continues to bring a spike in COVID-19 activity, far less profound than during the height of the pandemic but enough for people to

Travel, air-conditioned environments and waning immunity from shots may be factors

By RONG-GONG LIN II

notice and worry.

This summer’s jump is being fueled by the subvariant XFG, nicknamed “Stratus.”

“As we learn more about COVID, we are seeing that it has two surges a year: the late fall/early winter and in the summer, so we expect this trend of increased cases in the summer to continue,” said Dr. Elizabeth Hudson, the regional chief of infectious disease at Kaiser Permanente Southern California.

[See **COVID**, A8]

Thousands flock to ICE career expo

Candidates converge on Texas event as agency seeks to hire 10,000 agents.

By BRITTN Y MEJIA

ARLINGTON, Texas — They came from all across America to join President Trump’s deportation machine.

A Border Patrol agent, his firefighter wife and their 3-year-old daughter who drove nearly eight hours for jobs that could bring them closer to home. A man from Tennessee who wanted to apply because of “the way things have become with the illegal immigration and the strain it’s been on our economy.”

And a young Latino who was already catching flak for trying to work for Immigration and Customs Enforcement. A friend texted: “Oh hell no Ricardo I thought you was joking. I will not speak to you ever again if you become and ice agent ... You have a dad who was deported dude.”

They showed up Tuesday in Arlington, Texas, drawn by the Department of Homeland Security, which has mounted a campaign reminiscent of a wartime recruitment drive. Its images of Uncle Sam — wearing a baseball cap with the letters ICE or with an eagle behind him — tell people “AMERICA NEEDS YOU.”

“America has been invaded by criminals and predators,” the recruitment posts on social media read. “We need YOU to get them out.”

Last week’s two-day career expo marked the first major hiring event staged by ICE since the passage of the One Big Beautiful Bill Act, which earmarked about \$170 billion for border and immigration enforcement, including tens of billions of dollars for hiring deportation agents and other personnel. ICE officials say it’s the first of several hiring events planned around the country.

Homeland Security officials say that in less than two weeks, the agency received more than 100,000 applications, although it’s unclear how many were viable candidates. The department has loosened age restrictions for potential recruits and is offering hiring incentives such as bonuses of up to \$50,000 and student loan repayment benefits. ICE hopes to hire 10,000 deportation officers by the end of the year, although some worry that the expedited expansion could open the door to troubling hires.

Whether the agency will reach its goal remains to be seen, but a couple of days in Texas show there’s no shortage of applicants eager to join an agency that has become essential in Trump’s push to drive out immigrants who are in the country illegally.

[See **ICE**, A7]



RON JENKINS Getty Images

A BADGE worn by Matthew Elliston, ICE Enforcement and Removal Operations assistant director.

WHO’S ELIGIBLE? Developments raise questions about who can access updated vaccines. **CALIFORNIA, B1**



MYUNG J. CHUN Los Angeles Times

REUBEN COX, at his Silver Lake shop, created a popular guitar modification.

How small part from hardware shop helped alter the sound of indie rock

Guitar gadget strikes a chord. But who owns it?

By NATE ROGERS

Inside a wooden cabin of a building nestled on the outer edge of Silver Lake, Reuben Cox started messing around with a guitar and accidentally created a new chapter in the history of rock ‘n’ roll.

It was 2016 and Cox, who runs Old Style Guitar Shop — really more of a guitar shack — had gotten an idea while taking photos at an

Andrew Bird recording session. Producer and musician Blake Mills had brought out a 1950s Harmony electric banjo, which featured a removable rubber mute that could be wedged against the strings. It was a funky little instrument, and the muting device — designed to take the musical edge off, essentially — caught Cox’s eye.

The next day, Cox started tinkering around to see if something like it would work on a guitar and ended up wandering around Home Depot in search of the right part; in a Dadaist twist, he found the piece he needed in the toilet aisle.

“Very Duchampian,” he said, laughing as he remembered the process in an in-

[See **Guitar**, A10]

A U.S. fleet off the coast adds to ‘surreal’ feel in Venezuela

By MERY MOGOLLÓN AND PATRICK J. McDONNELL

CARACAS, Venezuela — U.S. warships steam toward the southern Caribbean. The Trump administration denounces embattled “narco-president” Nicolás Maduro and doubles a bounty on his head to \$50

million. Rumors of an invasion, coup or other form of U.S. intervention flood social media.

For the beleaguered people of Venezuela, mired in more than a decade of crisis — hyperinflation, food shortages, authoritarian rule and rigged elections — a new phase of anxiety is once again rattling nerves. Even

so, Venezuelans are trying to soldier on.

“We try to keep up our activities, our schedules despite the uncertainty,” said Leisy Torcatt, 44, a mother of three who heads a baseball school in a nation where a passion for sports helps fend off despair.

“Our daily problems con- [See **Venezuela**, A4]

WILL YOUR CONGRESSIONAL DISTRICT SHIFT LEFT OR RIGHT?

CALIFORNIA, B1

Rams, Chargers ready for battle

Our NFL preview also analyzes the AFC West, where the greatest collection of head coaches resides. **SPORTS**

Content creators anxious over AI

Some on YouTube are concerned that Google is training its text-to-video tool Veo on their videos without a choice to opt out. **BUSINESS, A11**

Weather

Sunny and warm. L.A. Basin: 93/67. **B10**

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